

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION · FREE SAMPLER

Is a Biology Degree Worth It in the AI Era? The 2026 Life Sciences Risk Score

The free sampler — the score by track, the six factors in brief, and the honest reasons to think twice. The complete profile goes deeper.

5.0

AI EXPOSURE · CLINICAL TRIALS / FIELD RESEARCH

where 10 is most at risk

Re-scored every six months. We publish where we might be wrong.

Quick answer: Clinical and field research scores **5.0 out of 10** for AI exposure, where 10 is most at risk. Wet lab research scores **5.2**. Bioinformatics — the computational, tech-forward branch — scores **7.1**, and a biology degree with no further qualification scores **7.2**. Life sciences is the field where the terminal is more exposed than the bench, which is the opposite of what most students assume.

The short answer for parents: a biology degree is a foundation rather than a destination, and it matters enormously what gets built on it. The protected work is hands-on, in a lab or a field, with judgment about physical systems. The exposed work is analysis at a screen — which is exactly where many students believe the future lies.

Life sciences AI risk score by destination

Every career in this index is scored 1–10, where **10 is most exposed** to AI. Same six factors, same weights, applied identically to a research scientist and a paramedic.

DESTINATION	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVE	BAND
Clinical trials / field research	4.2	4.6	5.0	+0.8	Moderate
Wet lab research scientist	4.5	4.8	5.2	+0.7	Moderate
Regulatory / QA in pharma	5.0	5.4	5.8	+0.8	Moderate
Laboratory technician	5.6	5.9	6.3	+0.7	Moderate–High
Bioinformatics / computational biology	6.3	6.7	7.1	+0.8	High
Degree only, no further qualification	6.4	6.8	7.2	+0.8	High

2023 and 2025 figures are reconstructed using current methodology, not archived from past editions.

How that compares: the median career in this edition scores around 5.5. Bedside nursing scores **2.8**. A business analyst scores **7.6**. Entry-level software development scores **8.1**.

Nothing in this field scores in the low band, which surprises people who think of biology as a science degree with medical-adjacent safety. It is not medicine. Medicine's protection comes from licensure, physical patient contact and legal accountability, and biology has none of the three.

Will AI replace biologists?

It is transforming what research looks like, in both directions at once.

AI IS TAKING	IT CAN'T TOUCH
Literature review and synthesis	Physical experimental work at a bench
Sequence analysis and annotation	Judging whether a result is real or an artifact
Protein structure prediction	Designing an experiment that answers the question
Statistical analysis and modeling	Fieldwork in actual environments
Data cleaning and pipeline work	Knowing when the sample was contaminated
Manuscript drafting and formatting	Deciding what is worth investigating

This field is unusual in that AI is simultaneously a threat and a demand driver.

Computational biology and drug discovery are growing precisely because these tools work — which creates jobs while automating a large share of the work inside them.

Why is bioinformatics more exposed than the bench? The six factors

How wet lab research rates against each. Ratings are 0–10 on each factor's own terms.

FACTOR	RATING	EFFECT ON RISK
How much of this job can AI already do?	6.5	↑ moderate exposure
How hard will it be to land that first job?	6.0	↑ moderate exposure
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	7.5	↓ good protection
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	5.0	↓ weak
Does the law require a licensed human?	3.0	↓ almost none
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	8.0	↓ strong protection

ONE FACTOR, WORKED THROUGH IN FULL

So you can see what the analysis actually looks like.

Does it have to be done in person, with your hands? — rated 7.5 at the bench, 1.0 at the terminal

Students choosing between wet lab and computational biology usually assume the computational route is the modern, future-proof one. Our scoring says the opposite, and this factor is why.

Wet lab work rates 7.5. Experiments are physical. Someone has to prepare samples, run the protocol, handle the equipment, and — critically — notice when something has gone wrong in a way the data will not reveal. A contaminated culture, a mislabeled tube, a reagent that has degraded. This is embodied craft knowledge, and it is why experienced bench scientists are valuable in ways that do not appear on a CV.

Bioinformatics rates 1.0. Inputs are data. Outputs are analysis and code. There is no physical component, no licensed accountability, and no requirement for anyone to be anywhere. That combination has produced the highest scores in this index everywhere it appears — and computational biology is not exempt because its subject matter is important.

The uncomfortable version: protein structure prediction, sequence annotation and much of standard genomic analysis are now substantially automated, and were among the earliest scientific tasks to be. A student choosing bioinformatics because it is technical and modern may be choosing the most exposed part of their own discipline.

This pattern recurs across the index and it is worth naming. In agriculture, precision agtech scores worse than field farming. In veterinary medicine, lab diagnostics scores worse than practice. In allied health, imaging analysis scores worse than hands-on therapy. **The technology-forward version of a physical profession is consistently more exposed than the**

physical version, because adopting the technology means moving toward the work the technology does.

The general lesson: "modern" and "protected" are not the same thing. Ask where the work physically happens, not how advanced it sounds.

Which life sciences careers are safest from AI?

Ranked by exposure, safest first:

1. **Clinical trials / field research** — 5.0. Physical presence, regulatory weight, coordination with people. 2. **Wet lab research** — 5.2. Embodied experimental craft and genuine novelty. 3. **Regulatory / QA in pharma** — 5.8. Accountability and regulated sign-off, with heavy documentation content. 4. **Laboratory technician** — 6.3. Physical, but increasingly protocol-driven and instrument-automated. 5. **Bioinformatics** — 7.1. Data in, analysis out, no physical or regulatory protection. 6. **Degree only** — 7.2. The general graduate market.

Is a biology degree still worth it in 2026?

It depends almost entirely on what follows it, and this is the field where that is most true.

The degree alone scores 7.2 — the same story as psychology. Biology is one of the most-taken science degrees, and the majority of graduates do not work as biologists. Without a postgraduate route or a specific technical specialization, it leads to the general graduate market.

The routes that hold up:

- **Medicine, dentistry, veterinary or allied health** — biology is a standard foundation for all of them, and all score dramatically better
- **Wet lab research with a doctorate** — genuine expertise in physical experimental work
- **Clinical trials and regulatory** — where accountability and process protection apply
- **Biology plus a domain** — bioengineering, environmental science, agriculture, public health

And one honest note on demand: AI-driven drug discovery is genuinely creating jobs. Some of them are the most interesting work in the sector. Most of them require a doctorate and computational skill, and they sit in the part of the field our scoring rates most exposed. Both

things are true, and a student should understand that the growth and the exposure are in the same place.

Worth asking any program: what proportion of graduates go on to postgraduate study or into laboratory roles, and what are the rest doing five years out?

Common questions

Will AI replace biologists? Not bench researchers or field scientists. It has substantially automated sequence analysis, structure prediction and literature synthesis — the computational core of the discipline.

Is a biology degree useless? No, but it is a foundation rather than a career. It scores 7.2 on its own and considerably better as preparation for medicine, allied health, or doctoral research.

Is bioinformatics a good career? It has real demand and genuinely interesting work, and it is the most exposed part of life sciences at 7.1. Both are true simultaneously.

Is biology safer than chemistry or physics? The pattern is similar across the natural sciences: physical experimental work is protected, computational and analytical work is not, and the degree alone is a general graduate credential.

Should my child do biology or nursing? They are very different bets. Nursing scores 2.8, takes two to four years, and leads directly to licensed practice. Biology scores 7.2 on its own and requires a further step to reach anything comparable.

Related careers

- **Medicine** — 2.1 surgery to 4.9 radiology
 - **Nursing** — 2.8 bedside, 5.4 desk-based
 - **Psychology** — 3.5 licensed clinical, 7.1 with the degree alone
 - **Agriculture, environment & conservation** — 4.0 farm management, 6.2 precision agtech
 - **Data science & analytics** — 8.2 entry analyst, 6.0 ML engineering
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What's in the life sciences Career Value Guide

This sampler tells you where life sciences stands. The full Career Value Guide tells you what to do about it.

	SAMPLER	CAREER VALUE GUIDE
Verdict, all destination scores, 3-year trend	✓	✓
Six-factor ratings	✓	✓
Reasoning behind every factor rating	one example	✓
How durable each protection is		✓
The growth-and-exposure paradox — why AI-driven discovery is both		✓
The honest downsides — postgraduate requirement, academic precarity, pay		✓
What's genuinely good about it — and who this work suits		✓
The AI-native advantage — how to prepare, and why this cohort has an opening		✓
Routes on — medicine, allied health, doctoral research, industry		✓
What the degree leads to without a further step — honestly		✓
Program evaluation checklist — lab time, placement, postgraduate progression		✓
Questions to ask a program — plus red flags		✓
Sourced further reading		✓
Discussion questions for parent and student		✓
A short version written directly to the student		✓
Technical scoring appendix		✓

GET THE CAREER VALUE GUIDE

Most families are weighing two or three careers seriously, and a few more they haven't ruled out. Pick the ones you need.

1 career	\$49	Choose →
3 careers	\$69	Choose →
Unlimited	\$99	Choose →

Each Career Value Guide includes everything in the table above, plus a short version written directly to the student and the technical scoring appendix. This edition and the next are included — we re-score every six months, so what you buy stays current for a year.

[Read a complete Career Value Guide free →](#) We publish one Career Value Guide in full, openly, so you can judge the depth before buying anything. Computer science is the one to read — it's the most surprising result in the index.

Pivotum scores thirty careers against AI exposure using a fixed, published methodology, re-scored every six months. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. We publish where we might be wrong.